

From 29 Down to One Up: Knicks Stun Spurs in Historic Finals Comeback

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Imagine being at Madison Square Garden, watching your team get absolutely crushed. The San Antonio Spurs, led by the towering Victor Wembanyama, built a 27-point halftime lead, the biggest ever by a visiting team in the Finals. By the third quarter, the Spurs were up 81-52. It felt over. But the New York Knicks had other plans. In a stunning **turnaround**, the Knicks outscored the Spurs 58-30 in the second half, completing the largest **comeback** in NBA Finals history. OG Anunoby tipped in Jalen Brunson's missed three-pointer with 1.2 seconds remaining, giving New York a 107-106 victory and a commanding 3-1 series lead. Brunson finished with 36 points, while Anunoby had 33. Coach Mike Brown praised Anunoby's crucial **offensive rebound**, calling it one of the biggest plays in Knicks history. The previous Finals **comeback** record was 24 points, set by Boston against the Lakers in 2008. The Knicks shattered that by five. The Spurs, who made 11 of their first 16 three-pointers, went ice-cold in the second half, hitting just 3 of 17 from deep. Wembanyama scored 24 points but shot only 9 for 25. 'We got on our heels we missed some shots,' said Spurs coach Mitch Johnson. 'It's disappointing, to say the least.' The Knicks, who had a 13-game winning streak snapped in Game 3, showed **resilience**. They also erased a 22-point fourth-quarter **deficit** against Cleveland earlier in the playoffs. This team simply refuses to quit. Even after Stephon Castle's free throws put San Antonio back ahead with 30 seconds left, the Knicks found a way. Now, they head to San Antonio for Game 5 on Saturday, with three chances to **clinch** their first championship since 1973. The Garden faithful left singing 'Don't Stop Believin' and for good reason.

Word Treasure

comeback -- A situation where a team or person recovers from a large deficit to win the game.

offensive rebound -- When a player grabs the ball after a missed shot, giving their team another chance to score.

resilience -- The ability to recover quickly from difficulties or setbacks.

deficit -- The amount by which a team is behind in a game or competition.

clinch -- To secure a victory or title so that it cannot be lost.

turnaround -- A dramatic change in a situation, from losing badly to winning.

Background you need

The New York Knicks are one of the NBA's original teams, but they haven't won a championship since 1973 -- longer than most current players have been alive.

Madison Square Garden (often called 'the Garden') is the Knicks' home arena in Midtown Manhattan, known for its loud fans and electric atmosphere.

Victor Wembanyama, the Spurs' 7-foot-4 French center, was the first overall pick in the 2023 NBA draft and is considered a once-in-a-generation talent.

The previous largest comeback in NBA Finals history was 24 points by the Boston Celtics against the Los Angeles Lakers in Game 4 of the 2008 Finals, a series the Celtics eventually won in six games.

Earlier in the 2025 playoffs, the Knicks had already shown their never-quit spirit by erasing a 22-point fourth-quarter deficit to beat the Cleveland Cavaliers.

Break it down

LEAD: At Madison Square Garden, Spurs build record 27-point halftime lead, later up 81-52

+ detail: biggest halftime lead by a visiting team in Finals history

KEY EVENT: Knicks outscore Spurs 58-30 in second half to complete largest comeback in Finals history

+ WHO: OG Anunoby tips in Jalen Brunson's missed three-pointer with 1.2 seconds left

+ SCORE: 107-106 victory, 3-1 series lead

+ STATS: Brunson 36 points, Anunoby 33

NEW RECORD: Previous Finals comeback record was 24 points (Boston vs. Lakers, 2008); Knicks surpass it by five

SPURS FALTER: After hitting 11 of first 16 three-pointers, go 3 for 17 in second half; Wembanyama shoots 9-for-25

TENSION: Spurs briefly retake lead on Stephon Castle's free throws with 30 seconds left, but Knicks still win

OUTCOME: Knicks head to San Antonio for Game 5 with three chances to clinch their first title since 1973

ATMOSPHERE: Garden crowd sings 'Don't Stop Believin' as a symbol of fan belief

Why it matters

This historic comeback shows how refusing to give up, even when things look impossible, can change history -- a lesson that applies far beyond sports, from school projects to personal challenges.

Test what you remember

1. What was the San Antonio Spurs' halftime lead in this game?
 - (A) 24 points
 - (B) 27 points
 - (C) 29 points
 - (D) 30 points
2. Who tipped in the game-winning basket for the Knicks?
 - (A) Jalen Brunson
 - (B) Victor Wembanyama
 - (C) OG Anunoby
 - (D) Stephon Castle
3. How many points did Jalen Brunson score in the game?
 - (A) 24
 - (B) 33
 - (C) 36
 - (D) 58
4. Which team previously held the NBA Finals comeback record?
 - (A) Los Angeles Lakers
 - (B) Cleveland Cavaliers
 - (C) San Antonio Spurs
 - (D) Boston Celtics
5. What was the Knicks' series lead after the game?
 - (A) 2-1
 - (B) 3-1
 - (C) 2-2
 - (D) 3-0
6. When did the Knicks last win an NBA championship before this series?
 - (A) 1984
 - (B) 1999
 - (C) 1973
 - (D) 2008

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: D 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Positive (Knicks' resilience): The Knicks proved that no lead is safe, demonstrating extraordinary mental toughness. This victory gives their long-suffering fans genuine hope of ending a 50-year championship drought, and it cements this team's legacy as one that never quits.

2. Negative/Critical (Spurs' collapse): The Spurs choked under pressure, squandering a seemingly insurmountable lead. Their ice-cold second-half shooting and defensive lapses will raise serious questions about their poise and coaching in crunch time, and a blown 3-1 series could define the young Wembanyama era.

3. Neutral/Analytical (Comeback frequency in the NBA): Huge comebacks are becoming less rare in modern basketball, partly because of faster pace and three-point shooting volatility. This game fits a pattern where a hot-starting team can quickly cool off, and the record-breaking margin highlights how fragile a lead can be in the Finals.

4. Forward-looking (What's next): If the Knicks close out the series, they will not only end a long title drought but also reshape the power balance of the Eastern Conference. For the Spurs, the psychological scar of this loss might either motivate a furious comeback or signal deeper problems that need addressing before they can contend again.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):